partnerships.[20] India has in recent years gradually delinked its strategic autonomy from the policy of non-alignment, enabling itself greater flexibility to move along the wider spectrum of alignments in its foreign policy.

In this volume, we analyse India's behaviour vis-à-vis China within the framework of balance-of-power theory. Hard balancing and bandwagoning are the two policy options at opposite extremes for a state in search of security. Although neither of these two policy options excludes the possibility of cooperating or competing with great powers on "the other side" of the alignment spectrum, there is a third option in between hard balancing and bandwagoning that belongs to the family of balance-of-power theory and which allows for a more equal mix of cooperation and competition, and that is hedging.

Even if balancing, bandwagoning, and hedging can be understood as strategies and policy choices, the aim of this edited volume is not to promote or recommend one particular of these three as the most viable strategy for Indian foreign policy towards China. Rather, we merely use these terms and their theoretical foundations as a framework to examine and understand change and continuity, status, and future directions of how India manages the rise of China.

Balancing and bandwagoning

In international politics, where self-help and anarchy are the hallmarks, the basic goal of each state is to survive, to preserve its sovereignty and autonomy.[21] Balancing, bandwagoning, and hedging are three strategies states can follow to obtain this goal. The motivations for choosing balancing, bandwagoning, or hedging are most significantly influenced by polarity – the number of great powers in the international system.[22] In a unipolar world, when it is costly for secondary powers to balance against the sole